

Hollow Soul - Unity

Next 10 Milestones: M42-M51

Prepared April 28, 2026 after the M41 current milestone audit baseline.

Roadmap Intent

This roadmap assumes the project is currently past M41: the validation baseline exists, the core branch loop is in place, and the player build systems have begun. The next stage should avoid adding random disconnected features. The strongest path is to make the current systems readable, improve feel, add room-level challenge depth, expand content safely, and then re-lock a shareable beta slice.

Guiding principle: gameplay data remains authoritative; art, UI, and effects should explain and support the systems without becoming hidden gameplay logic.

One-Page Summary

Milestone	Focus	Primary Outcome
M42	Player Build UX + Pickup Clarity	A player can always answer: what am I holding, what changed, what did I replace, and why did my stats change?
M43	Combat Feel V2 + Damage Feedback	Damage, danger, hits, deaths, and temporary safety windows are obvious within one room of play.
M44	Shield / Armor Behavior V2	Defense feels like a deliberate playstyle option rather than a hidden stat only.
M45	Room Hazards + Interactive Physics V1	At least three rooms can be made meaningfully different without adding new enemy types.
M46	Encounter Director + Difficulty Curve V1	Branches have visible pacing: warmup, escalation, pressure rooms, reward relief, and boss setup.
M47	Challenge Mode V2 + Curated Seeds	Challenges can be used by us for QA and by players as readable alternate run goals.
M48	Content Expansion Lock V1	The prototype has enough validated content variety to support multiple short runs without feeling identical.
M49	ArtPass Production Integration II	Replacing art remains safe, testable, and clearly separated from gameplay logic.
M50	Story, World Identity + Run Framing V2	The run loop has a reason to exist beyond mechanics, even if the storytelling remains light.
M51	Vertical Slice Beta Lock + External Playtest Build	Someone outside the project can play the slice, understand the loop, and give useful feedback without us sitting next to them.

Recommended Sequence

Phase	Milestones	Why this order matters
Stabilize player understanding	M42-M43	The build system and combat feedback must be readable before more mechanics are layered on top.
Add deeper mechanics	M44-M46	Defense, hazards, and encounter pacing create real moment-to-moment depth.

Phase	Milestones	Why this order matters
Expand playable variety	M47-M49	Challenges, content counts, and ArtPass integration make the prototype feel less procedural-graybox.
Lock identity and handoff	M50-M51	Story framing and beta lock turn the work into a shareable vertical slice.

M42: Player Build UX + Pickup Clarity

Intent: Make the M27-M30 build systems understandable in normal play before adding more mechanics.

Implementation targets:

- Add a readable build panel showing character, active weapon mode, melee/ranged weapon, armor, active item, consumable card, coins, souls, stamina, and active set.
- Add pickup comparison cards for weapons, armor, active items, consumable cards, and passive rewards before replacement applies.
- Add clear acquisition/use messages for items, cards, weapons, armor, coins, souls, and synergy activation.
- Add save/continue display tests so restored runs show the same build state the gameplay uses.

Acceptance: A player can always answer: what am I holding, what changed, what did I replace, and why did my stats change?

M43: Combat Feel V2 + Damage Feedback

Intent: Turn functional combat into readable combat without changing the branch architecture.

Implementation targets:

- Add player/enemy hit flash, short hit pause, impact VFX hooks, stronger projectile impact feedback, and death bursts.
- Tune knockback, contact damage timing, grace periods, invulnerability frames, and enemy windups.
- Separate player damage, enemy damage, shield/defense mitigation, and environmental damage feedback messages.
- Add manual QA checklist for Windows and Vision Pro comfort/readability.

Acceptance: Damage, danger, hits, deaths, and temporary safety windows are obvious within one room of play.

M44: Shield / Armor Behavior V2

Intent: Move defense from passive numbers toward active readable defense choices.

Implementation targets:

- Add shield behavior as a run equipment/ability layer: hold guard, stamina drain, reduced frontal damage, and short push/parry window.
- Let armor modify guard cost, defense, speed, and knockback resistance without becoming gameplay-authoritative art.
- Add two prototype shields or shield-like defensive items, with simple tags for future synergies.
- Add tests for guard stamina, parry timing, push radius, mitigation, and save/restore compatibility.

Acceptance: Defense feels like a deliberate playstyle option rather than a hidden stat only.

M45: Room Hazards + Interactive Physics V1

Intent: Make rooms interesting beyond enemy count while keeping room data authoritative.

Implementation targets:

- Add hazard entities: spikes, spike timers, pits/holes behavior, breakable rocks, push blocks, and explosive barrels as prototype content.
- Extend Room Designer tools/validation for hazards and interactive props where safe.
- Ensure hazards serialize through HollowRuntime V2-compatible metadata or a forward-compatible companion section.
- Add room validation so hazards never spawn on safe start, doors, rewards, or impossible traversal routes.

Acceptance: At least three rooms can be made meaningfully different without adding new enemy types.

M46: Encounter Director + Difficulty Curve V1

Intent: Replace isolated encounter rolls with a branch/world-aware pacing model.

Implementation targets:

- Add encounter budget rules using world index, branch depth, room role, footprint size, player build strength, and seed.
- Create encounter archetypes such as intro, swarm, turret nest, charger lane, splitter pressure, mixed elite, treasure guard, and boss approach.
- Add deterministic difficulty bands and validation that no branch creates impossible early rooms.
- Expose encounter diagnostics in dev HUD/reports for tuning.

Acceptance: Branches have visible pacing: warmup, escalation, pressure rooms, reward relief, and boss setup.

M47: Challenge Mode V2 + Curated Seeds

Intent: Turn challenge mode into a repeatable content/testing tool and a player-facing mode.

Implementation targets:

- Add fixed-seed challenge entries with rule modifiers: low HP, melee-only, ranged-only, no shop, elite rooms, boss rush, and secret hunt.
- Keep challenge runs transient unless explicitly promoted; they should not mutate active profile runs.
- Add challenge completion summary and developer replay notes, including seed and major rewards.
- Add challenge validation to ensure every listed challenge can load and reach its first room.

Acceptance: Challenges can be used by us for QA and by players as readable alternate run goals.

M48: Content Expansion Lock V1

Intent: Set concrete minimum content counts and validate them as part of the prototype.

Implementation targets:

- Target pool: 12 approved rooms, 4 secret rooms, 3 boss-room candidates, 10 encounter definitions, 8 weapons, 10 passive rewards, 5 active items, 6 consumable cards, and 4 characters if time allows.
- Add spreadsheet/PDF content inventory generated from catalogs so Rafal and Martin can see missing art, VFX, audio, and logic coverage.
- Promote approved Room Designer exports into the branch room pool only after validation.
- Add content lock report listing gaps, duplicates, invalid tags, missing ArtPass bindings, and fallback usage.

Acceptance: The prototype has enough validated content variety to support multiple short runs without feeling identical.

M49: ArtPass Production Integration II

Intent: Convert more placeholder content into visual-only production-ready prefabs without changing gameplay authority.

Implementation targets:

- Integrate Rafal asset batches through ArtPass prefab roles for player, weapons, armor, enemies, boss, doors, hazards, rewards, shop, portals, and VFX cues.
- Add animation hooks for idle, attack, hit, death, pickup, portal, door unlock, and hazard activation.
- Strengthen ArtPass validation: pivot, bounds, no gameplay colliders, no gameplay scripts, Addressables labels, material budget, and Vision-safe hierarchy counts.
- Generate an artist handoff report with exact missing roles and screenshots where possible.

Acceptance: Replacing art remains safe, testable, and clearly separated from gameplay logic.

M50: Story, World Identity + Run Framing V2

Intent: Turn the M39 framing seed into a more coherent game identity across worlds and runs.

Implementation targets:

- Define World 1-3 themes, room tone, boss meaning, hub role, shopkeeper/proxy identity, soul/coin fiction, and extraction meaning.
- Add short in-game text beats for run start, world transition, boss key pickup, secret room, boss defeat, hub return, and final extraction.
- Add lore shard reward type as optional non-power pickup that records discovered fragments run-locally or profile-locally, depending on design decision.
- Create a writer/designer-facing workbook update that turns current open questions into locked direction.

Acceptance: The run loop has a reason to exist beyond mechanics, even if the storytelling remains light.

M51: Vertical Slice Beta Lock + External Playtest Build

Intent: Freeze a small but real playable beta candidate for handoff and feedback.

Implementation targets:

- Lock one root seed and one curated challenge seed, with validated branch content, build systems, hazards, combat feel, ArtPass bindings, and story framing.
- Run full current audit, M24 QA, M25/M40-style handoff reports, EditMode, PlayMode smoke, and manual QA checklist.
- Produce Windows development build when environment supports it, plus Vision Pro bounded/immersive readiness reports.
- Create a playtest packet: build notes, controls, known issues, feedback form prompts, and suggested test route.

Acceptance: Someone outside the project can play the slice, understand the loop, and give useful feedback without us sitting next to them.

Implementation Notes

- Do M42 before adding more item/weapon systems. The current build stack is powerful but needs player-facing clarity.
- Do M43 before increasing difficulty. Better feedback gives us permission to make rooms harder without making them feel unfair.
- M45 and M46 should be tested together because hazards and encounter pacing can accidentally create impossible rooms.
- M48 should include a hard content inventory target. This helps Rafal produce assets against exact missing roles rather than vague art needs.
- M51 should be treated as a real external handoff candidate, even if the audience is small. That discipline will expose the right problems.

Suggested Immediate Next Step

Start with M42. It is the highest leverage milestone because it makes the existing character, weapon, armor, item, card, currency, and synergy systems visible and understandable. Without that pass, later systems will technically work but feel like invisible math.